

## **In the east**

Meanwhile, recognizing the demographic importance of the Indo-Gangetic plains, Stephenson, proposed a railway link between Calcutta and the North-West Frontier in 1841. This plan did not find favour with the EIC either. Stephenson was determined to stand by his railway project, however, and in 1843, he reached out to the local population in Calcutta where he acquainted them with the potential benefits the railway connections would provide. He also collected and compiled data to support this mammoth project.

Having garnered enough support, Stephenson wrote about the proposal in the *Englishman* in 1844. In it, he discussed the ambitious railway link that criss-crossed the land – from Calcutta to Mirzapur and Delhi, with links to Ferozepur, and a line from Bombay to Hyderabad and Coringa, to be continued to Calcutta. Both these lines would also be connected at Mirzapur. From Hyderabad, a line would branch off south to Madras, from where one line would go to Calicut and the other would link Tirunelvely. In July of the same year, he put forth his idea to the Bengal government, which assured him a thorough consideration of his proposal. At his insistence, the first survey was prepared by the Bengal government for a 675-km line from Calcutta to Mirzapur in the United Provinces.

## **Against all odds**

By early 1845, provisional committees had been formed for the EIR and GIPR. When the question of investment arose, Stephenson, with support from the Bengal government, managed to get the backing of mercantile houses for his company, East India Railway Company, later called EIR. In his document, *Report Upon the Practicability and Advantages of the Introduction of Railways Into British India*, he spoke extensively about the advantages of rail communication, including those in trade, the details of routes that would be adopted, and the backing of the Government. He presented his dealings and correspondence with the Government of Bengal and other documents he believed would help convince the public to invest in the venture. In January 1845, the EIR finally submitted its prospectus to the Court of Directors. Seeing the growing